

I'm amazed that most people perilously operate one crisis away from financial ruin. We have become a nation of undisciplined spenders and consumers. We have become a nation where unfettered spending and material extravagance write our obituaries in the ink of stress. If you're held hostage to your lifestyle, you aren't wealthy, because you lack freedom.

THE PROPER USE OF MONEY

Money doesn't buy happiness when it's misused. Instead of money buying freedom, it buys bondage. "Wealth" and "happiness" are interchangeable, but only if your definition of wealth hasn't been corrupted by society's definition. Society says wealth is "stuff," and because of this faulty definition, the bridge between wealth and happiness collapses. When you don't feel wealthy, you're likely to try to conjure that feeling. You buy icons of wealth to feel wealthy. You crave feelings, respect, pride, and joy. You want admiration, love, and acceptance. And what are these feelings supposed to do for you? You expect deliverance into happiness.

And that's the bait. We equate the corrupted definition of wealth with happiness, and when it doesn't deliver, expectations are violated and unhappiness is the consequence.

Used properly, money buys freedom, and freedom is one parcel in the wealth trinity. Freedom buys choices. The fact is, there are plenty of poor people who live richer than their overworked upper-middle-class counterparts because the latter lack freedom, they lack solid relationships, and they lack health—all deleterious effects of working a hated job five days a week for 50 years.

Money secures one agent of the wealth formula, freedom, which is a powerful guardian to wealth's sibling ingredients: health and relationships.

- 1) Money buys the freedom to watch your kids grow up.
- 2) Money buys the freedom to pursue your craziest dreams.
- 3) Money buys the freedom to make a difference in the world.
- 4) Money buys the freedom to build and strengthen relationships.
- 5) Money buys the freedom to do what you love, with financial validation removed from the equation.

Are any of the above likely to make you happy? I bet they will. They certainly won't make you unhappy.

LIFESTYLE SERVITUDE: THE TRAP OF THE SIDEWALK

Sidewalkers are embroiled in Lifestyle Servitude, where life is forced into a rat race, a constant tug-of-war between lifestyle extravagances and work, a self-perpetuating merry-go-round of work for income, income for lifestyle, and lifestyle for work. Wherever there's Lifestyle Servitude, there's a systematic erosion of freedom.